> millennium before Christ, and even before then, the peoples of the Punjab and Sind were living in well-built cities and were in possession of a relatively mature culture with a high standard of art and craftsmanship and a developed system of pictographic writing.[4]

Since Marshall wrote those historic words scores of Harappan Civilisation sites, large and small, have been excavated on India's side of its border with Pakistan. With one major exception, virtually all the major settlements were located on the alluvial plains of the Indus and along its tributaries in the Punjab. The outstanding characteristic of this Harappan Civilisation was its extensive urbanisation, involving a score or so of city-states or nucleus cities each with satellite towns and villages, and with trading ports dotted along the coast, covering a territory larger than the farmed lands of ancient Mesopotamia and Egypt combined.[5] A combination of seeming stability and self-sufficiency provided the platform for advances in ceramics, handicrafts, metallurgy and other trades. Thanks to their fondness for toys modelled out of clay, we know that they used several types of bullock-drawn carts with solid wheels but not the light horse-drawn chariot. Similarly, there are numerous depictions on Harappan seals of bulls, elephants, rhinos, water buffalo, lions, tigers, supposed unicorns and other creatures, but not a single depiction of a horse or a horse-drawn chariot.[6]

Some two thousand of these stone seals or sealings have so far come to light and they provide revealing insights into what the Harappans may have thought and believed. Most show one or more animals or human figures accompanied by a row of very distinctive pictographs, logographs or written characters. Ever since Cunningham took note of this 'pictographic writing' scores of well-qualified philologists and hundreds of enthusiastic amateurs have tried to make